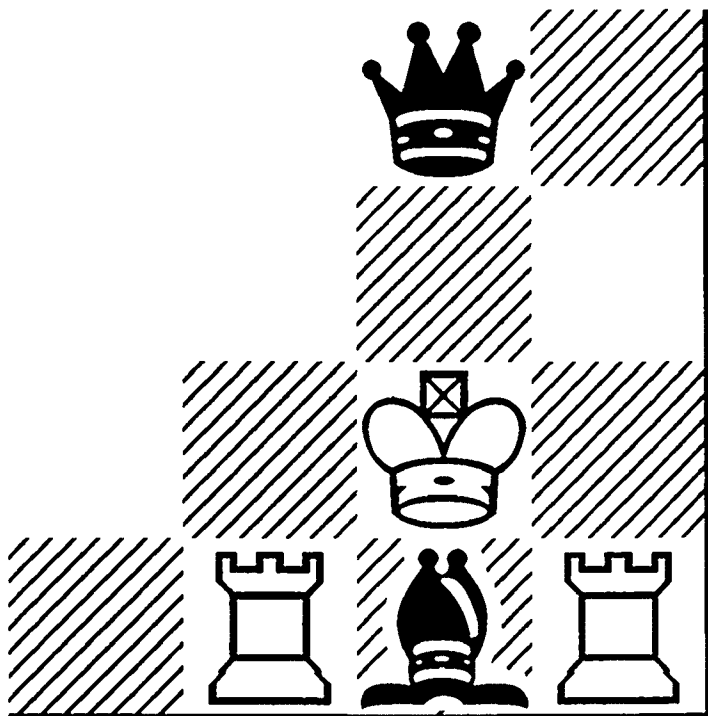


Chapter Nine

White Plays an Early h2-h3

■ White Plays 6 Bg5, Delaying Nf3

■ White Plays 6 Nf3



1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 h3 0-0 (Diagram 1)

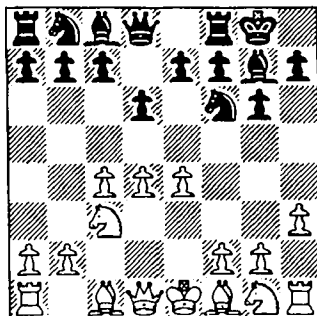


Diagram 1
The quiet 5 h3

Why does White play h3?

The move h2-h3 has two main ideas. The first is to support the advance g2-g4. This is played both to gain space on the kingside and to dissuade Black from playing ...f7-f5. The second idea is to pave the way for Be3 without having to worry about ...Ng4. Very often the bishop will go to g5 first but if Black attacks it with ...h7-h6 then it drops back to e3. The intentions behind h3 are similar to those behind f3 in the Sämisch Variation but the two variations usually lead to quite different types of games. In the favour of h2-h3 is the fact that White can still develop the king's knight to its natural home f3 and that the dark squares are not further weakened. On the other hand, h2-h3 does nothing to protect the all important e4-square.

How does Black battle against these h3 systems?

The first thing Black needs to do is stake his claim in the centre. It is possible to play with ...c7-c5 but this takes us into the Modern Benoni and outside the scope of this book. Anyway, it is more reliable for Black to play the traditional ...e7-e5. Black will usually play for ...f7-f5 even after White has played g2-g4. The move ...Qe8 to unpin the knight on f6 is a useful tool if Black doesn't want to let White have it all his own way on the kingside. On other occasions Black will advance on the queenside (...c7-c6, ...a7-a5, ...a5-a4, ...Qa5 are all typical moves) while sometimes he tries to play on both sides of the board simultaneously. The basic rule for Black is that he must play actively and with purpose. If he dithers in the opening then he might find that White suddenly has a clamp all over the board and that it is too late for offensive action. Then he will just have to await his fate.